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FOR WRITERS · A FIELD GUIDE

Skip the *two years.*

Seven things I wish I'd known before querying agents.

I wrote my book in three weeks. Getting it ready for agents, marketing and publishing took me **two years.** Here's what I learned — so you don't lose the time I did.

One thing per page.

ROBYN LINN

WHY THIS MATTERS

Agents decide in pages, not chapters.

Thinking about a book, writing one or holding a finished draft — this is the part nobody hands you. Get these seven right and your manuscript is ready to be read the way agents read.

01 Write for impact

02 Let the scene do the talking

03 Choose your voice — then hold it

04 Know where your book sits on the shelf

05 Prove there's a readership

06 Build to the turn

07 Earn the ending

Each page ends with one thing to try today.

01



THE STAKES

Write for impact — not the market.

An agent decides fast. Give them a reason to keep reading before page two.

Most agents will tell you to write to market. Write for impact instead — there has to be a reason you're saying what you're saying.

That's where stakes come in. Before page two, your main character needs something to lose. The reader catches it — and has to keep reading to see how it plays out.

> TRY THIS
>
> Open your first two pages. Circle the line where we learn what your character could lose. No circle? That's your rewrite.

02

DIALOGUE

Let the scene do the talking.

Filler paragraphs are where readers — and agents — put a book down.

Dialogue carries more of your book than you think — but it has to flow, and it has to replace the filler.

Cut the paragraphs that explain: this is what happened, this is how it looked, this is how she felt. Build your voice around the scene itself — until the storytelling becomes the dialogue.

TRY THIS

Find one paragraph that summarizes a conversation. Rewrite it as the conversation.

03

VOICE

Choose your voice — then hold it.

Consistency is what makes a manuscript read like a book, not a draft.

Lyrical and poetic. Investigative, like a journalist. Blunt and choppy — short sentences, raw and present. Reflective and intuitive.

Whichever is yours, it has to hold across the entire manuscript. That's the craft. It also shapes your comps — the books you compare yours to will share some of the way you speak.

> **TRY THIS**
>
> Read a page from your opening and a page from your final chapter aloud. Do they sound like the same writer?

04

COMPS

Know where your book sits on the shelf.

Comps are how a publisher pictures selling your book.

Choose three to five titles from the last three years. Some can echo your voice — but mostly, agents want to see your themes, genre and spine.

Wrote a murder mystery? Find the recent murder mysteries yours would sit beside in a bookstore. That's how publishers will sell your manuscript.

TRY THIS

Find the exact shelf — in a store or online. List the titles from the last three years that would sit next to yours.

05

READERSHIP

Prove there's a readership.

A publisher has to believe someone is already waiting for this book.

Going traditional? Publishers want to know your book is relevant to what's selling now.

They'll say platform doesn't matter much. They'll still check your social media — to see whether you can carry this message and whether people lean in. If that isn't in place yet, build it while you pitch.

TRY THIS

Share one piece of your book's core message this week. Watch what people respond to — that's your angle.

06

THE MIDPOINT

Build to the turn.

The midpoint shift is what keeps a reader from drifting.

After the inciting incident and the stakes in your opening chapter, build toward a moment where something changes. Your character learns, discovers or lives through something.

At the midpoint, there's a shift — now she has to see through a different lens because of what she's been through.

TRY THIS

Name your midpoint in one sentence: Before this, she believed ___. After it, she sees ___.

07

TENSION

Earn the ending.

Agents read for tension — and for a payoff they didn't see coming.

Build tension between your characters across the whole book. Many agents read for exactly this.

When it resolves in the final chapter, don't tell us what happened — let us see it and feel it. And shape it so the payoff isn't obvious until it lands.

TRY THIS

Read your last chapter. Mark every line that tells us how it resolved. Turn each one into a moment we witness.

RL

HI, I'M ROBYN LINN

Writer, editor and award-winning producer.

For 26 years I've worked with entrepreneurs around the world — coaching, consulting and guiding them to turn a vision or passion into an online business and brand.

My own coaching program earned **over $3.9 million**, and I've supported celebrities, the US Army and some pretty big founders.

Let's talk about your book.

A focused call on your project — where it stands, what it needs and your next move.

Connect with me →

alchemyattraction.com/write-with-robyn